

Domestic Politics in 2025: South Korea's Polarized Democracy After Martial Law

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In the wake of the stunning martial law crisis, what is the status and future of South Korea's polarized democracy? Much debate has focused on whether the intensity of polarization has abated under the Lee Jae-myung administration. I shift focus to the axis of polarization and its prospects for change. Protestors in the aftermath of the crisis were noticeably younger, more female, and diverse. Cautious optimism surrounded the "born democratic" generation as the potential movers of the Cold War nationalist axis that has long polarized the left-right over unification with North Korea. I test this optimism against data from the Korean General Social Survey. I find that support for unification remains the most consistent and significant predictor of leftist identification in the population, even for the young generation. A new axis around gender equality is emerging, but its partisan pull is limited to women. Whether the martial law crisis serves as a force of realignment or retrenchment for South Korea's polarized democracy appears to depend less on street-level politics and more on party elites and leadership.

Key Words: martial law, polarization, democracy, unification, gender

I. Introduction

The year 2025 was historic for South Korea. A stunning martial law decree on the evening of December 3rd, 2024, citing threat from "anti-state forces," was swiftly followed by an equally stunning display of resistance by the opposition in the National Assembly and citizen protestors. The decree was overturned within hours, a snap

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presidential election was won by the progressive candidate Lee Jae-myung within months, and former president Yoon Suk-yeol was tried and sentenced to life in prison for insurrection in just over a year. Democracy appeared recovered just as fast as it was almost lost.

Last year's annual review article, "South Korea's Democracy at a Crossroads," focused on the structural causes of this seismic event in South Korea's democratic politics (Hur 2025). After the martial law crisis, headlines quickly diverged between extremes. Some characterized the crisis as an aberration—the unfortunate result of Yoon's idiosyncrasies—while others saw it as the inevitable climax of vicious polarization. Some opined South Korea's democratic recession while others touted its democratic resilience.

The term "crossroads" in the title was carefully chosen to reflect the idea that the martial law crisis could indeed be both. The crisis was a moment of triumph for civil society and institutional safeguards that ultimately overturned the decree in six hours, but it also revealed the systemic weaknesses of a zero-sum polarized party system (Park 2025). The review article focused on the structural causes of the latter, tracing its roots back to the long shadow cast by the Cold War on South Korea's domestic polarization between left and right over national identity (Cho and Hur 2025). I argued that the martial law crisis would remain the tip of a very dangerous iceberg as long as the axis of polarization remained fixated on the existential issue of unification with North Korea. Such nationalist polarization is not just more intense. Because disagreements over national identity involve exclusive ownership of the state, it breeds the kind of zero-sum competition where winning and eliminating the other side becomes the end goal, even at the cost of democracy.

The visual of a crossroads—of two divergent pathways—was also meant to capture the political agency of party elites, citizens, and national entrepreneurs in actively choosing the future. The only way out of the vicious cycle of nationalist polarization, the piece argued, was through. Partisan de-alignment away from the nationalist axis and toward domestic bread-and-butter issues could drain the poison. Polarization over issues such as how to best do redistribution, education, or demographics may still be intense, as real policy disagreements in democracies tend to be. But because polarization over such issues assumes a shared nation-state—that both sides are still rooting for the same team—it would keep political competition within the bounds of a "hot family feud," as the early democracy scholar Dankwart Rustow (1970) put it. The piece closed with cautious optimism based on the noticeably younger, more female, and diverse demographic of citizen protestors in the wake of martial law. The crisis appeared to have galvanized

the typically apathetic "born democratic" generation to not take democracy for granted. Perhaps this young generation could become the new electorate with distinct interests and demands that incentivize the parties to move beyond the Cold War axis.

This year's article returns to the crossroad to see, directionally, where South Korea's polarized democracy is headed. Is the martial law crisis a turning point for realignment or retrenchment of existing divides? I critically assess the optimism for change against the best available data using the Korean General Social Survey (KGSS). The aim is to offer a neutral examination of how the empirical reality stacks up against the many questions and assumptions after the crisis. Is gender the new political cleavage? Is unification a relic of the past and a mere performative tool used by political parties? Does the young generation behave like a distinct electorate? I find that while there are glimmers of potential change, unification still looms largest in predicting left-right identification in the South Korean population, regardless of generation. The immediate political crisis from martial law may be closing, but the crisis of South Korea's polarized democracy appears far from closure.

II. Normalization after Martial Law

The mission statement for South Korea's domestic politics in 2025 can be summed up in one word: normalization. South Korea demonstrated remarkable speed and success in efforts to normalize after the rupture caused by the sudden martial law decree on the evening of December 3rd, 2024. Within six hours, martial law was lifted by the swift mobilization of the opposition in the National Assembly. On December 14, 2024, after several failed attempts to reach a quorum due to boycotting by Yoon's conservative People Power Party (PPP), the National Assembly successfully voted to impeach Yoon and remove him from office. In the following months, the interim president changed hands between ministers due to successive impeachments by the opposition.

The year began with seemingly endless street protests in the bitter January cold, this time divided on Yoon's resistance to an arrest warrant for investigation. Conservative groups held up signs with "Stop the Steal" against what they saw to be an unlawful impeachment, while progressive groups borrowed K-pop anthems to chant against what they saw to be a reversion to authoritarianism. Violence erupted when a group of pro-conservative young men stormed the Seoul Western District Court in protest of the arrest warrant, injuring police officers and vandalizing government buildings (Lee 2025). Yoon eventually relented. On January 26th, he was indicted for insurrection. On April

4th, the Constitutional Court unanimously ruled in favor of impeachment, permanently removing him from office.

On June 3rd—six months from the martial law decree that upended the country overnight—progressive candidate Lee Jae-myung narrowly won the snap presidential election. The conservative candidate Kim Moon-soo accepted defeat and expressed respect for the people's decision. Given the exceptional circumstances, Lee took office the very next day without the usual transition period. With this peaceful change of power from the conservatives to progressives, the immediate political crisis of a leadership vacuum had effectively closed.

Once in office, President Lee's mission was political normalization at home and abroad. With the progressives controlling both the executive and parliamentary branches, the administration moved quickly to push institutional reforms to make future martial law decrees more difficult, such as adding legal procedures and barring military personnel from entering the National Assembly. Prosecution of the key players involved in the martial law crisis also progressed swiftly.

Abroad, President Lee largely practiced the pragmatic diplomacy he had preached during the presidential campaign. He avoided the usual progressive fault lines that tend to incense backlash from the conservatives, such as hostility toward Japan or the United States. Instead, his first diplomatic visit as president was to Japan to discuss cooperation on his way to meet with U.S. President Donald Trump. The Lee-Trump meeting achieved the diplomatic goal of establishing a positive working relationship as the two countries headed into tough trade and tariff negotiations. In the meeting, Lee stated that he would serve as "pacemaker" to Trump's role as "peacemaker" toward North Korea. This was a strategic move of balance. By broaching re-engagement with North Korea, he satisfied the progressive base that supports unification. But by deferring the protagonist role to the United States, he also avoided falling into the conservative trope of accusing the left of being pro-North Korea.

The transitional year rounded out with South Korea serving as the host of APEC in late fall, which cemented the perception of political normalization after the martial law crisis. President Lee effectively used the APEC platform to bring together China's Xi Jin-ping and Trump for a bilateral meeting amid an intensifying economic standoff between the two countries. Japan's new prime minister Sanae Takaichi also attended, continuing the cooperative footing established by Lee's earlier visit to Japan. Meanwhile, APEC's substantive agenda struck a balance between strengthening regional economic ties while also leaning into South Korea's national interests in solving the population decline and investing in artificial intelligence.

By many counts, South Korea successfully survived the immediate political crisis after the martial law decree. The electoral system, courts, and parliamentary process functioned as designed, resulting in a speedy and peaceful transition of power in the executive. President Lee—despite worries that he could be an echo of die-hard progressive Moon Jae-in or hopes that he would be a reconciliatory like Kim Dae-jung (Shin 2025)—has so far proven to be more of a pragmatist who tows the line somewhere in between.

Yet political normalization captures only a narrow aspect of democratic resilience. Even failed attempts at an executive power grab can yield downstream effects on future democratic stability (Han 2025). None of the institutional reforms to executive and parliamentary power directly address the structural issue at the root of the crisis: the nationalist axis of left-right polarization. De-alignment away from the unification issue that has long been the centripetal force of partisan competition requires harder and less palatable changes to party recruitment and leadership selection practices. Those reforms have yet to happen on either side.

Meanwhile, the aftershocks from the martial law crisis are still palpably felt in all corners of South Korea's polarized society. Explicitly political sermons fill the halls of left- and right-leaning churches, political Youtubers on both ends are idolized, and deep animosity colors how citizens see the other side in Manichean terms of good versus evil (Sneider 2025). The frequency and fervor of street protests may have abided. But the depth of division laid bare by the martial law crisis was hard to unsee. As the trials of Yoon and his inner circle continued, with the special prosecution seeking up to the death penalty for Yoon, there was an overwhelming sense of waiting for the other shoe to drop.

Tremors resurfaced as the trial verdicts were announced in early 2026. The former prime minister and briefly acting president Han Duck-soo and the former Defense Minister Kim Yong-hyun each received 23-year and 30-year prison sentences for abetting insurrection, effectively putting both behind bars for the rest of their lives. On February 19th, former president Yoon was found guilty of leading insurrection and received a life prison sentence. This is the lesser of the two punishments for insurrection by South Korean law, the other being the death penalty. In justifying the life sentence, the presiding judge cited Yoon's advanced age and restraint from using lethal force during martial law. The decision was met with an outburst of street protests once more, with pro-Yoon supporters holding up "Make Korea Great Again (MKGA)" signs while an anti-Yoon faction chanted for the death penalty citing betrayal of the nation. For either side, the verdict clearly offers little closure.

Is political normalization masking the vicious cycle of nationalist polarization that is seething just underneath the surface, ready to be reignited with a match? In this uncertain phase of domestic politics, many hopes and predictions have risen about the future of South Korea's polarized democracy. Some claim that gender is the new axis, that the unification issue is a relic of the past, or that the martial law crisis has fundamentally reset the nature of party politics. Certainly, a great deal of optimism was placed on the noticeably younger, more female, and diverse demographic of protestors in the aftermath of martial law. Could the mobilization of this "born democratic" generation in support of democracy be a silver lining from the crisis?

This new "political subjectivity" is not simply younger, but represents a generation with distinctly gendered political traumas towards the state and conservative power specifically (Lee 2025). As political sociologist Yoonkyung Lee notes, young women in their 20-30s came of age through the Sewol ferry disaster of 2014, the Gangnam station femicide in 2016, Park Geun-hye's impeachment in 2016-17, Yoon Suk-yeol's explicitly misogynistic presidential campaign in 2022, and the Itaewon disaster of 2022, where women were the predominant casualty. Based on this lived history, it is unsurprising that so many young women showed up to protest Yoon's martial law decree, which many saw as the epitome of masculine abuse of power. Could these women also be the agents of political change in South Korea's polarization?

In the next section, I examine such narratives against the best available survey data using the Korean General Social Survey (KGSS). A definitive answer to how polarization will evolve is premature, but a directional assessment is possible, especially as the latest KGSS wave took place in the spring of 2025, after the martial law decree.

III. Axis of Left-Right Polarization

This section shows how the empirical reality stacks up against hopeful assessments of change in South Korea's polarized democracy. I start by analyzing how unification as the axis for left-right identification in the electorate has varied over time and across generations, relative to other issue cleavages such as class or gender. My aim is not to offer a prediction or a validity test, but simply to describe the patterns of polarization across a nationally representative sample.

There is no shortage of political surveys in South Korea, but the KGSS is singular in that it is the only recurring nationally representative survey based on probability sampling, rather than quota sampling. What this means is that while most other surveys

will give accurate estimates of levels of opinion in the population, the KGSS is the only reliable survey for statistical inference, such as modeling the relationship between different attitudes or variables. The KGSS cumulative dataset runs from 2003 to 2025 (Kim *et al.* 2025), including the most recent wave conducted in March of 2025 after the martial law crisis.

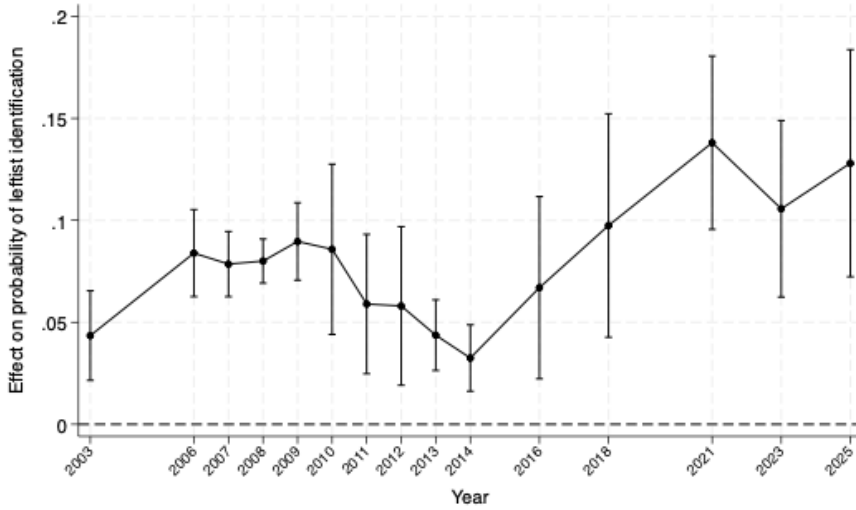
The KGSS contains a set of core political questions that it asks in almost every wave. I focus on these items as they offer the most comprehensive over-time picture of change or stability in the axis of polarization. I begin by analyzing the relationship between leftist identification and support for unification to see how the nationalist axis has varied over time.

To measure left-right identification, I use the following question (*partylr*): "To what degree do you think of yourself politically liberal or conservative? [Very liberal, somewhat liberal, neither, somewhat conservative, very conservative]." I code this as a binary variable to capture the probability of leftist (versus independent or rightist) identification.¹ Support for unification is measured with the following core question (*unifi*): "To what extent do you think the unification between South and North Korea is necessary? [Very necessary, somewhat necessary, somewhat unnecessary, very unnecessary]." I code this as a continuous variable to capture the strength of support for unification.

Figure 1 shows how support for unification predicts leftist identification over time. The estimates, shown with 95% confidence intervals, are marginal effects from by-year logistic regressions controlling for education, subjective class, gender, and age, with region fixed effects. The result includes every wave that the KGSS asked both questions, offering the most complete over-time picture where reliable data exist. The figure shows that over the last two plus decades, support for unification has had a consistent and positive effect on the probability of identifying left. It has increased in importance in the past decade since after 2016, when Park Geun-hye was impeached and the conservative dominance in South Korean politics began to wane. The pattern captured by the KGSS appears at odds with claims that unification is no longer a relevant axis of polarization or that it is simply performative rhetoric by party elites.

One may wonder if the apparent resonance of the unification issue is an artifact of population composition. Given the fertility decline, the South Korean population is top heavy in the older generation for whom the Cold War axis remains more salient.

¹ The substantive conclusions would be no different had I chosen to focus on rightist identification, only in the other direction. I focus on the left as current political developments in South Korea demand a better understanding of the bases of leftist identification.



Estimates are marginal effects of support for unification based on by-year logistic regressions predicting leftist identification, controlling for education, class, gender, and age, with region fixed effects. Bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on region clustered standard errors.

Figure 1. *Leftist identification and support for unification over time*

To check, I divide the sample by three distinct political-economic generations in South Korean politics. I choose this generational approach over simply using age categories by decades or arbitrarily splitting old versus young generations. A wealth of political socialization scholarship has shown how coming-of-age during distinct windows of citizen-state experiences imprint worldviews that shape people's party and regime allegiances in the long-term (Neundorf and Pop-Eleches 2020; Ghitza, Gelman, and Auerbach 2023).

In South Korea's modern history, scholars have generally pointed to three distinct political eras: the authoritarian developmental era, the democratization era, and the post-democracy/post-Asian Financial Crisis era (Koo 1993; Shin 2012). These eras are punctuated not only by the passage of time, but by critical junctures in South Korea's citizen-state relationship. I have defined each generation as the birth cohort who came of age and lived their young adulthood through these distinct eras.

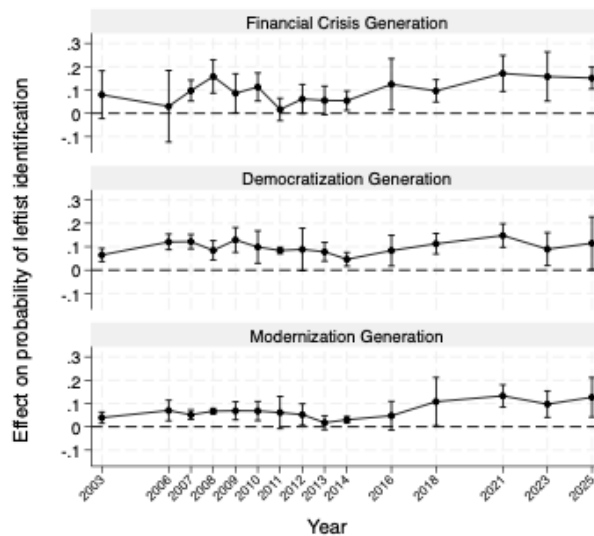
The oldest is the *Modernization Generation* born between 1910 and 1965, who primarily came of age during South Korea's authoritarian developmental era. This generation lived through successful developmental policies by the authoritarian regime—the lineage faction of today's conservatives—that catapulted South Korea from war-torn poverty to a competitive global economy. This era was defined by the ethos of state-led development as the path to national survival under the looming security threat from

North Korea in the aftermath of the Korean War.

In between, the *Democratization Generation* are people who were born between 1966 and 1981 who primarily came of age during South Korea's democratization and early consolidation era. This generation enjoyed increased social mobility and improved living standards from successful state-led development. At the same time, they also witnessed and participated in the oppositional push for stronger political rights and protections, eventually culminating in South Korea's democratization in 1987. Many civil society leaders from this generation who took part in the pro-democracy *minjung* movement became part of the core faction of the progressive party.

The youngest generation is the *Financial Crisis* generation born from 1982 onwards who primarily came of age in the post-Asian Financial Crisis era. The forced market liberalization from the financial crisis dramatically restructured the South Korean economy, decimating certain sectors that were no longer competitive globally. These market changes led to dramatically tightened social mobility and rapidly increasing income inequality, creating a sense of futility and disillusion with the state (Lee 2018). This generation is also the "born democratic" generation who came of age after South Korea's democracy had survived the delicate infant years.

Figure 2 replicates Figure 1, but separately by each generation. For the older Modernization and Democratization Generations, we see that support for unification is



Estimates are marginal effects of support for unification based on by-year logistic regressions predicting probability of leftist identification, controlling for education, class, and gender, with region fixed effects. Bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on region clustered standard errors.

Figure 2. Leftist identification and support for unification by generation

almost always a positive and significant predictor of leftist identification over the two decades. Perhaps surprisingly, that is also the case for the youngest Financial Crisis Generation. The 95% confidence intervals make the estimates in the early 2000s statistically insignificant, but that is mainly due to the smaller sample size of this generation in those years. Directionally, even for the young generation, support for unification has a significant positive effect on the probability of identifying left and has grown in importance over the last decade.

What of the widespread assumption that the younger generation no longer cares about unification? On a relative basis, the Financial Crisis Generation cares *less* about unification, with only 46 percent supporting it versus 73 percent in the oldest Modernization Generation. But on an absolute basis, that means that the near majority of the young generation in a nationally representative sample still supports unification as necessary. The Cold War axis that has long defined left-right polarization in South Korean politics appears still very much relevant. Claims that the unification issue is a relic of the past or purely performative by partisan elites do not correspond well with the empirical reality at the mass-level.

IV. Young Generation as the New Electorate

In this section, I assess the optimism surrounding the young generation as a new electorate with distinct issue interests that can potentially shift the major parties away from the nationalist axis centered on unification. How does unification stack up against other emergent issues that the young generation cares about, such as redistribution, religion, or gender? Has the relative importance of such issues changed over time?

To capture the largest sample and widest time horizon possible, I focus on items that are part of the core political battery and have been asked repeatedly across the KGSS waves. While this limits the set of issues I can examine and their specific question wordings, the trade-off with the ability to see over-time patterns is worthwhile. A key issue that has become salient among the young generation is redistribution and welfare. Income inequality in South Korea is disproportionately high given its GDP. This pain point is mostly sharply felt among the Financial Crisis Generation who came of age in the era of market liberalization that severely shrank job opportunities and social mobility (Park 2011; Jang and Shin 2021). With the continuing fertility decline, the young generation is also feeling the welfare burden of an aging population. To measure support for redistribution, I use the following question (*goveqinc*) that has been asked

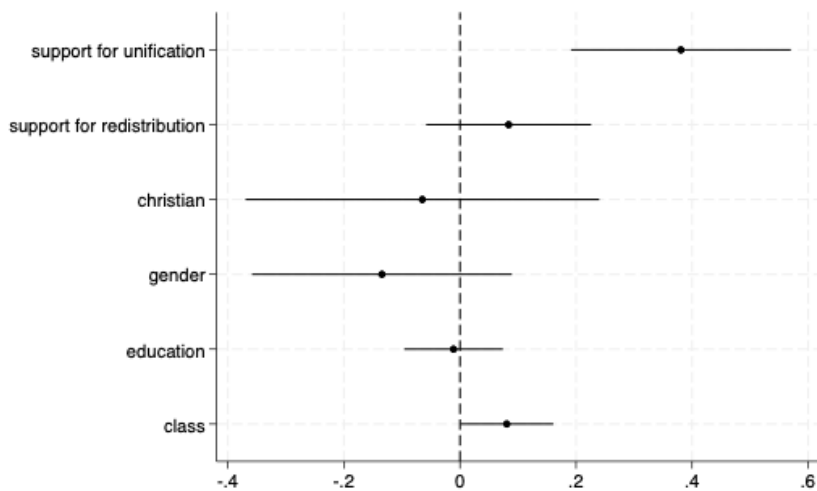
in years 2003, 2009-2011, 2014, and 2021-23: "How strongly do you agree or disagree that it is the government's responsibility to make incomes more equal? [Strongly agree, somewhat agree, neither, somewhat disagree, strongly disagree]." I code this as a continuous variable measuring strength of support for redistribution.

Another alternate axis is religion, especially as young Christian men have leaned politically far right and socially conservative in recent years. Christians and the conservative party have always had a special relationship in South Korea, dating back at least to the Christian exodus from the north during the Korean War, linking the Christian faith with anti-Communist attitudes (Moon and Jun 2011; Hong and Paik 2021). The role of Christian missionaries in rebuilding post-war South Korea during the authoritarian period further strengthened this link, carrying over to the contemporary period as electoral support for the conservatives—the authoritarian successor party—and authoritarian nostalgia (Kang 2020). The relationship has recently intensified, however, as part of a transnational awakening of Christian conservatism on the heels of Trump's embrace of Christianity as the moral backbone of his Make America Great Again (MAGA) movement in the United States (Lee 2025). This connection explains the prevalence of the American flag and "Stop the Steal" signs among pro-Yoon supporters after the martial law crisis, which were references to Trump's claims of election fraud for the 2020 presidential election he lost. To examine the relationship between Christianity and left-right identification, I create a binary index for Christian identifiers using the religion affiliation question (*relig*) in the KGSS.

I also consider two emergent axes around gender and class. For reasons already discussed, many analysts see gender as the new cleavage of the young generation, with men leaning right and women leaning left. The KGSS 2025 wave contains a special module dedicated to gender equality attitudes, which I explore in-depth in the next section, but the core question battery in the cumulative dataset does not contain great questions on gender. I therefore use a binary index for male versus female in the analysis to simply assess how gender correlates with left-right identification. The other emergent axis I explore is subjective class (*rank*) to see how claims of a rising populist left intersect with classist interests in the young generation. I code this as a categorical variable with four levels: low class, lower middle class, upper middle class, and upper class. The resulting dataset with all variables of interest covers years 2003, 2009, 2010, 2011, 2014, and 2021 for a total of 1411 subjects from the Financial Crisis Generation.

Figure 3 shows how support for unification stacks up against other emergent cleavages in predicting leftist identification in the young Financial Crisis Generation. The estimates, shown with 95% confidence intervals, are coefficients from a logistic regression predicting

the probability of leftist (vs. independent or conservative) identification with region and year fixed effects. Class emerges as a significant predictor of leftist identification, but in the opposite way from what populist narratives would suggest: higher, not lower, class perception is associated with greater odds of identifying left. But the most striking finding is that even after accounting for a person's position on various emergent issues, support for unification remains the most significant predictor of leftist identification. Figure 3 captures the average effect of these factors in the cumulative sample. Since the sample contains respondents from separate survey years, a null average effect could mask meaningful changes in the importance of these factors over time. I therefore replicate the analysis by survey year to look for over-time changes from 2003 to 2021.

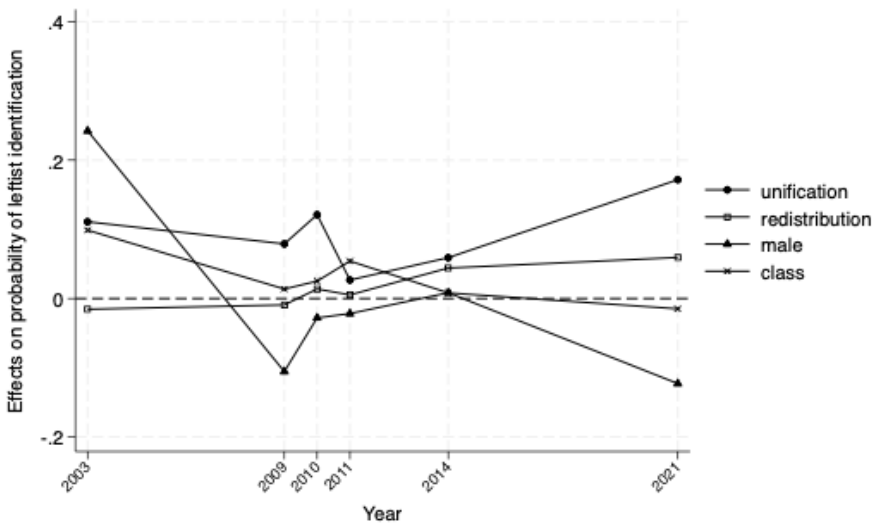


Estimates are from a logistic regression predicting odds of leftist identification with region and year fixed effects. Bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on region clustered standard errors.

Figure 3. *What predicts leftist identification in the young generation?*

Figure 4 shows the results of that analysis without confidence intervals for ease of visual interpretation. While support for unification has varied in predictive power, waning during the 2011-2014 heyday of back-to-back conservative incumbencies, it has always been positively associated with leftist identification and since 2014 has grown in importance. Despite worries of the leftist resurgence being fueled by a classist populist wave, we see that the reliability of class as a predictor has waned recently. Higher subjective class rank was positively associated with leftist identification in the early 2000s, but has gradually faded into a non-factor by the early 2020s. Support for redistribution appears to have a growing relationship with leftist identification over time, but its effect

is still small. Finally, being a man used to have a significant positive effect on the probability of identifying left in the early 2000s, but over the last two decades, that association has gradually faded. If anything, being a man in 2021 has a slightly negative effect on the probability of identifying as left, which accords with observations that young women have taken a more central role in the leftist opposition, especially in the aftermath of the martial law crisis.



Estimates are from by-year logistic regressions predicting probability of leftist identification with region fixed effects. Confidence intervals redacted.

Figure 4. Predictors of leftist identification in the young generation over time

This exploration suggests that hopes of the young generation serving as an impetus for partisan realignment in South Korean politics are at best premature. Among the potential new issue cleavages considered including redistribution, class, Christianity, and gender, support for unification remains the most consistent and powerful predictor of leftist identification in the young generation—just like the rest of the older electorate. While there are glimmers of potential shift, particularly around gender, the patterns are not yet strong enough to warrant claims of a new electoral base away from the Cold War axis.

V. Gender as an Emergent Axis

I take a deeper dive into the thesis that gender is the new cleavage. In the previous

section, as a trade-off to maximize time coverage in the KGSS, I was limited to using respondent sex as a proxy for gender-based attitudes, which is a crude measure. Fortunately, the KGSS 2025 wave includes a detailed European Social Survey module on gender, granting the opportunity to explore the partisan consequence of gender issues in a more nuanced way.

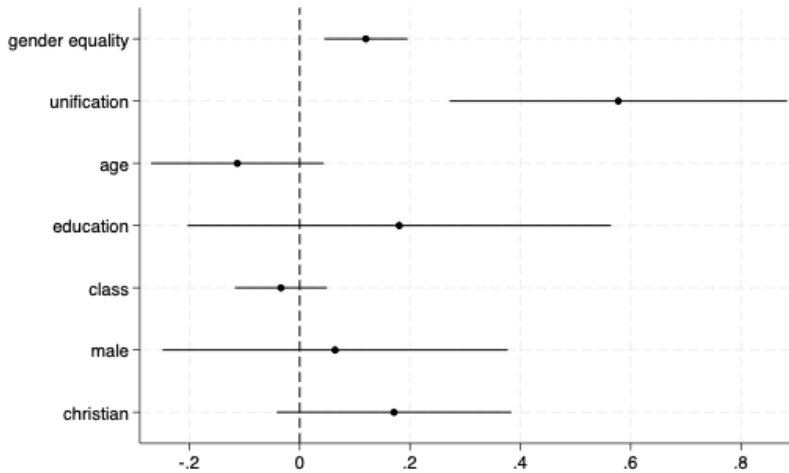
The gender module includes a four-question battery (*eqwrkfam*, *eqldrpol*, *eqnumbus*, *eqpayeco*) on attitudes toward gender equality across the realms of family, politics, workplace, and economy. The survey asks respondents whether they see gender equity in the following statements to have a negative or positive effect:

- The effect that gender equity in employment will have on family
- The effect that gender equity in political leadership will have on politics
- The effect that gender equity in hiring will have on the company
- The effect that gender equity in incomes will have on the economy

I code increasing positive responses to each item (weakly/somewhat/very negative=0, weakly positive=1, somewhat positive=2, very positive=3) and create a gender equality index by combining responses to all four statements. Respondents with no positive responses are coded as no support, 1-3 positive score as weak, 4-7 positive score as moderate, and 8-12 positive score as high in support for gender equality. Only 16 percent of women show no support for gender equality, whereas more than one in four men—27 percent—see gender equity as having a negative effect on society. On a scale of 0 to 3 in possible level of support for gender equality, women have an average score of 1.31 compared to 1.16 for men.

Figure 5 shows how the gender equality index predicts leftist self-identification for all respondents in the 2025 KGSS, controlling for other issue attitudes and demographics with region fixed effects. We see that greater support for gender equality has a positive effect on the probability of identifying left. Support for gender equality is a more reliable predictor of leftist identification than subjective class perception or being Christian. However, it is still a less significant predictor compared to support for unification. In subgroup analyses not shown here, I find that the patterns do not differ substantively across the three generations.

I further explore whether the partisan pull of gender equality differs for men versus women. I replicate the analysis from Figure 5 but model how respondent gender conditions the effect that support for gender equality has on leftist identification. Figure 6 shows that support for gender equality has a positive effect on the probability of leftist identification



Estimates are from a logistic regression predicting odds of leftist identification with region fixed effects. Bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on region clustered standard errors.

Figure 5. *Leftist identification and support for gender equality*



Estimates are from a logistic regression predicting probability of leftist identification with region fixed effects. Bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on region clustered standard errors.

Figure 6. *Leftist identification and support for gender equality by gender*

among women, although it is just shy of statistical significance. But it has a null effect among men. The pattern is mirrored when predicting rightist (conservative) identification: greater support for gender equality is negatively associated with conservative identification for women, but has a null effect among men.

The findings from this descriptive exercise illuminate several interesting patterns about gender as the new political cleavage. In the 2025 KGSS sample, I find that support

for gender equality is positively associated with greater odds of leftist identification in the electorate. While there is no over-time data for comparison, as this was the first time KGSS included a gender module of this kind, stance on gender equality is a more reliable predictor of leftist identification in 2025 than class perceptions or being Christian. However, the strength of its pull to the left (or push away from the right) still pales in comparison to one's stance on unification. Across all generations of the South Korean electorate, unification is still the most powerful axis for left-right identification. Finally, despite the prevailing narrative of spiteful young men flocking to the conservatives for their misogynistic stance on gender equality issues, the data show that in fact, gender equality issues are a more powerful pull-factor to the left for women. Policy investments into improving gender equality for both men and women would be a more effective electoral strategy than trying to woo only half of the electorate with gender discriminatory rhetoric.

VI. Martial Law: Retrenchment or Realignment?

South Korea's domestic politics in 2025 was defined by the seismic martial law crisis that occurred on the evening of December 3rd, 2024. The stunning decree by former president Yoon not only threatened democracy, but also exposed the depth of partisan division among both political elites and South Korean society. By many counts, South Korea pulled itself out of the immediate shadow with impressive efficiency. Within months, the Constitutional Court ruled in favor of impeachment, permanently removing the former president from office, and prosecution for a variety of indictments ranging from abuse of power to insurrection began. A successful snap presidential election concluded with an immediate concession by the conservative candidate after the vote count, peacefully changing power to the progressives with Lee Jae-myung's victory. Lee's presidency, which kicked off six months after the martial law decree, has so far successfully steered the country toward political normalization. Although it is still early in his five-year tenure, president Lee has adeptly avoided the usual partisan fault lines regarding relations with North Korea, the United States, and Japan, keeping to his campaign promise of pragmatic, South Korea first diplomacy.

Yet the verdicts for former president Yoon and his inner circle announced in early 2026—and the divided public response—show that the deep wounds in South Korean society are far from healing. Political normalization is the best outcome one could have hoped for South Korea in the aftermath of the martial law crisis. But it does not

fundamentally solve the root cause of the crisis. Last year's annual review article argued that while contemporary factors such as Yoon's outsider background or successive veto attempts by the opposition may have shaped the specific timing and form of the crisis, the possibility of such a breaking point was endemic to the origins of South Korea's democracy and party system.

South Korean democracy was in many ways the product of nationalist conflict. In authoritarian South Korea after the Korean War and national division, the emergent progressive opposition to the incumbent authoritarian regime coalesced around an alternative nationalist vision to the state-sanctioned one (Lee 2011). The competing nationalist visions fundamentally disagreed on the necessity and way of unification to achieve Korea's true nation-state form. This difference subsequently shaped the polarizing views between the left versus right on how South Korea should engage with its former colonizer Japan, its Cold War ally United States, North Korea's Cold War ally China, and North Korea itself. The progressives are typically hostile to Japan and the United States, which they see to be barriers to unification and Korea's fullest self-actualization, whereas the conservatives are typically more cooperative with Japan and the United States and hardline against North Korea. It would be a mistake to characterize such differences as mere diplomatic strategy or hawkish versus dovish inclinations. They represent mutually exclusive, competing views of Korea's nationhood.

When the major political parties are polarized on such a nationalist axis, it fundamentally distorts the rules of the democratic game (Hur and Yeo 2024). The opposition is not a fair competitor, but an existential threat to be eliminated. The goal is not to improve representation, but to win at all costs and capture the state in "our" national vision. Certainly, other forms of polarization based on liberal versus conservative ideology or class conflicts are no less intense. But because such conflicts do not inherently involve ownership of the state by one group, they do not produce the kind of existential, zero-sum competition observed in South Korea's democracy. The vicious cycle of partisan purges and constitutional hardball that characterize South Korean politics, which climaxed with the martial law crisis, are not symptoms of just any kind of polarization. They are symptoms of polarization trapped around a nationalist axis.

Deeper normalization, then, can only occur when there is meaningful partisan de-alignment away from the Cold War nationalist axis and realignment around a South Korea-centric axis. In the aftermath of the martial law crisis, there were various hopes of a silver lining. The younger, more female, and diverse demographic of street protesters—and real moments of political alliance-building between formerly disparate groups—seemed to signal the rise of a new electorate with distinct policy preferences from

the older generation's crisis of unification. Another popular narrative centered on the rise of gender as a new cleavage. Growing inequality and fiercer market competition began taking a gendered frame under the decade of conservative incumbency, during which several state failures—including the impeachment of the first woman president Park Geun-hye and the Gangnam station femicide—took on a misogynistic bent. Gender tensions crescendo-ed under Yoon's presidential campaign, which made explicitly misogynistic appeals to attract disillusioned young men to the conservative camp. Would gender and gender issues become the new political axis going forward?

In this year's review, I assessed the potential future of South Korea's polarized democracy by analyzing how such narratives stack up against the empirical reality. Using the KGSS, I found reasons for both hope and doubt. There are small but detectable signs of change, consistent with other studies that find evidence of diversifying axes of polarization in South Korea (Cheong and Haggard 2023). For the young generation, support for redistribution is steadily gaining importance over time, although its effect on leftist identification is still not statistically significant. In the 2025 wave, support for gender equality emerges as a significant predictor of leftist identification, but mostly among women. The consistent finding, however, was that support for unification is still the most reliable and powerful predictor of leftist identification across all generations. Hopes that the political galvanization of the "born democratic" generation will usher in a new era of partisan politics seem premature at best.

What do these findings bode for South Korea in 2026 and beyond? The takeaway should not be that change is impossible. The data, which capture patterns of leftist identification among the masses, suggest that the onus for change lies more with partisan elites than with street-level politics. The fact that unification is still the strongest predictor of leftist identification for the young generation—which cares decisively less about unification than the older generation—shows that the partisan axis is primarily shaped top-down, from political elites to voters. Even if the electorate cares about issues outside of the nationalist axis, if the major parties do not offer campaign platforms on such issues, there is little room for electoral incentive or punishment. Instead, voters who come to identify as left or right for various reasons end up adopting their party's core stance on unification, perpetuating the nationalist cycle. This is not at all to say that street-level politics do not matter. The martial law crisis politically activated new groups, which if sustained and grown into new issue factions, could help to decenter South Korea's nationalist axis in the long run. But such change will be hard and take longer without party elites actively taking issue ownership outside of the nationalist axis.

The narrow issue boundary of partisan competition was put on display during the

2025 debates for the snap presidential election. The debate between the two major candidates was almost entirely focused on which side had betrayed the nation and the semantics of North Korea's alleged role in the martial law crisis. Other issues that are ripe of issue ownership, such as redistribution or housing costs or immigration, were mostly delved into by the minor Democratic Labor Party and the splinter conservative Reform Party candidates. The two major candidates also discussed such issues, but for such a polarized and charged election, they diverged surprisingly little on their proposed solutions, offering no real choice for voters outside of the nationalist axis.

Whether the martial law crisis is remembered as the turning point for realignment or retrenchment of South Korea's polarized democracy will depend heavily on the foresight of party leadership on both sides. Acute changes in South Korea's socioeconomic environment, most notably the fertility decline and welfare crisis, present ample electoral incentive and urgent need for the major parties to diversify their programmatic platforms beyond the Cold War shadow. Often one does not recognize the value of something until it is lost. Perhaps the brightest silver lining from the martial law crisis is the reminder of the value of South Korea's democracy. South Korea's democratic identity implicitly undergirds many aspects of its national status, from its global cultural influence to serving as the host for APEC to being regarded as a regional leader. Defending that at all costs can be a powerful point of consensus.

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